Literature Review Grading Rubric

INTL-I 522 Global Development · Final Project, Option 2 · Fall 2026

Each row is one component of the literature review, weighted as shown. Find the cell that best describes your review on that component; that cell is the letter grade for that component. A review can earn an A on one row and a C on another. One question runs through every row: after finishing your review, would a colleague who is new to this question know what the field has established, where the important disagreements are, which side the evidence currently favors, and what research would help settle them?

Component	A Excellent	B Good	C Fair	D Poor	F Missing / fails
Formatting & Citation **10%** *10–15 pages, single-spaced; fonts, margins, heading, and page numbers as specified; in-text citations present and correct; bibliography in APSR format.*	Length and every formatting specification met exactly. Every claim about what a study found or argued is attributed to that study. In-text citations and bibliography follow APSR style consistently, with at most a trivial slip, and every work cited in the text appears in the bibliography (and vice versa).	Specifications met with one or two minor lapses (e.g., missing page numbers, an off-spec heading). Citations present throughout, with a handful of APSR inconsistencies or a few mismatches between text and bibliography.	Several departures from the specified format, or length noticeably outside the 10–15 page range. Some findings are reported without attribution; citations and bibliography are inconsistent or not in APSR style.	Specified format largely ignored. Citations sparse, so the reader often cannot tell whose finding is being described; bibliography incomplete or in a different style throughout.	Specified format not followed; citations or bibliography missing.
Organization & Style **20%** *Introduction (question, why it matters, scope, organizing scheme, and preview of the review's main conclusions); sections organized around debates or themes; topic sentences that make analytic claims; conclusion; clean, formal, precise prose.*	**Introduction** states the question, explains why it matters for development, sets the boundaries of the review, explains how the review is organized, and previews its main conclusions. **Section headings** name debates or claims, so the headings alone convey the structure of the field. Topic sentences make analytic claims about the literature rather than announcing the next study. Transitions explain how one section bears on the next. A summary table or figure is used where it helps the reader compare studies. **Conclusion** draws the threads together. Prose is error-free, formal, and precise.	Introduction and conclusion present, but one element is thin (e.g., no explanation of scope, or the main conclusions are held back until the end). Headings are generic ("Background," "Literature," "Discussion") rather than naming debates. Organization is sound overall, but some sections slip into study-by-study summary. A few errors or patches of unnecessary jargon.	Introduction or conclusion missing or merely summarizes. Organization follows authors or publication dates more than ideas, so the review is mostly a sequence of summaries. Paragraphs frequently open with an author's name rather than a claim. Frequent errors; imprecise or informal phrasing gets in the way.	Little discernible organization; the reader must reconstruct the structure of the field on their own. Errors are pervasive and impede comprehension.	Not written as a literature review (e.g., an argumentative essay with a few citations, or an annotated bibliography in paragraph form); organization and prose prevent the reader from following the argument.

Component	A Excellent	B Good	C Fair	D Poor	F Missing / fails
Question & Coverage **15%** *A precisely defined development question; key concepts defined; coverage of foundational and current scholarship, across disciplines and methods; inclusion of work that cuts against the review's conclusions.*	Poses a specific question about development (often a causal one), not just a topic, and defines its key concepts and how the literature measures them. Coverage is authoritative: foundational works and the most recent scholarship, peer-reviewed research across the relevant disciplines and methodological traditions, and the major contributions on every side of each debate, including work that cuts against the review's conclusions. The principles used to select the literature are stated.	Question is clear and coverage is solid, but with gaps: a major contribution or recent line of work is missing, coverage leans heavily on one discipline or method, or key concepts are used without definition. Most sources are scholarly.	Describes a topic or general area rather than a defined question, so the boundaries of the review are unclear. Coverage is selective or dated; relies heavily on a few sources, textbooks, or policy reports where peer-reviewed research exists. Contrary findings are thin or missing.	Question confused or too broad to review in 15 pages. Coverage is thin and appears to reflect what was easy to find rather than what the field considers important.	No identifiable question; little or no engagement with scholarly literature, or the question is not about development.
Synthesis & Adjudication **25%** *Literature organized around its debates; competing positions and the causal claims behind them clearly identified; explanation of why scholars disagree; a defended position on where the weight of the evidence lies.*	Organizes the literature around its central debates and identifies the competing positions in each, stating the causal claim each position advances. Explains *why* scholars disagree (different definitions, measures, cases, time periods, levels of analysis, or methods) and where they actually agree. Takes and defends a position on each major debate: which side the weight of the evidence currently favors, or the conditions under which each claim holds. Characterizes positions fairly, including the ones the author rejects.	Debates are identified and the positions are described accurately, but the explanation of why scholars disagree is thin, or the adjudication is tentative ("more research is needed") where the evidence would support a judgment. Some sections synthesize well while others summarize.	Groups studies by topic but does not identify the debates within them, or lists positions without comparing them. The author's own position is unclear or asserted without engaging the evidence on the other side. Some positions are caricatured.	Mostly serial summary of individual studies with little comparison. No position taken, or a position that ignores much of the literature reviewed.	No synthesis; the review is a list of summaries, or it misrepresents what the literature argues.
Evaluation of Evidence **20%** *Identifies the kinds of evidence scholars use (e.g., cross-national data, natural experiments, RCTs, case studies, process tracing, ethnography); assesses causal inference, measurement, generalizability, and scope conditions; connects differences in evidence to differences in findings.*	Identifies the kinds of evidence used to test the main claims and assesses the strengths and limits of each for the question at hand: how well studies establish causation, how well concepts are measured, and how far findings travel beyond the cases and periods studied. Shows how differences in evidence account for differences in findings. Weighs the quality of studies rather than counting how many support each side. Treats claims honestly where the evidence is weak, including on the side the author favors.	Evaluates evidence for the main claims, but unevenly: some studies are assessed carefully while others are reported at face value, or the discussion of methods is generic and not tied to specific studies. Connections between evidence and disagreement are noted but not developed.	Reports findings with little attention to how they were produced. Treats all studies as equally credible or tallies studies on each side. Methodological criticism, where present, is generic ("correlation is not causation") and not tied to specific studies.	Little or no evaluation of evidence; findings reported as settled facts. Evidence is cited selectively in support of a conclusion reached in advance.	No engagement with the evidence behind the literature's claims.

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Paths Forward **10%** *Specific suggestions for how the literature could move forward that follow from the gaps and disagreements identified; awareness of what the state of the literature implies for practice.*	Proposes specific, feasible directions that follow directly from the gaps and disagreements identified in the review: particular questions, research designs, data, cases, or contexts that would help settle a debate, and why they would do so. Explains what the current state of knowledge implies for policy and practice, and how confident practitioners should be in it.	Suggestions for future research are sensible and linked to the review, but general ("more studies in Africa," "better data"), or the explanation of what they would settle is thin. Implications for practice are mentioned briefly.	Suggestions are generic or only loosely connected to the gaps the review identified. Implications for practice are missing or overstated.	A sentence or two calling for more research, with no specifics.	No suggestions for future research.

What the letter grades mean for a literature review

"A" reviews give a colleague new to the question an authoritative overview of the field. They are organized around the field's debates, explain why scholars disagree, evaluate the evidence on each side with care, and take a defended position on where the weight of the evidence lies. They close with specific suggestions for research that would help resolve what remains open. The prose is precise, formal, and free of errors.

"B" reviews meet the requirements of the assignment and show a solid grasp of the literature, but something holds them back from being authoritative: coverage has a noticeable gap, some sections drift into summary, evidence is reported more than evaluated, or the author is reluctant to adjudicate debates the evidence could settle.

"C" reviews show a limited grasp of the literature or the genre. They are often organized as a sequence of study summaries, with little comparison across studies and no clear position. Coverage is selective or dated; findings are reported without attention to how they were produced; and suggestions for future research are generic. Errors or imprecise phrasing make the review harder to follow.

"D" reviews do not identify a clear question or the debates around it, cover little of the relevant scholarship, offer little evaluation, and are carelessly executed, with weak structure and frequent errors.

"F" reviews are missing major components, are not written as literature reviews, or do not address a question of development.